

## MODULE 04 / 40

# House Finch

*Haemorhous mexicanus***QUICK STATS**

|          |                                   |
|----------|-----------------------------------|
| Length   | 5.0 – 6.0 in (12.7 – 15.2 cm)     |
| Wingspan | 8.0 – 10.0 in (20.3 – 25.4 cm)    |
| Weight   | 0.6 – 0.9 oz (16 – 27 g)          |
| Lifespan | Up to 11 years (avg. 2–3 in wild) |

**PRESENTATION**

The House Finch is one of the most abundant and widespread songbirds in North America, found from coast to coast in virtually every habitat where humans have settled. Originally native to the western United States and Mexico, it was introduced to the eastern US in the 1940s when illegal pet trade birds were released on Long Island, New York. It has since colonized the entire continent with remarkable speed. The male's rosy-red head and breast make it one of the most colorful regular visitors to backyard feeders, while the streaked brown female is a master of camouflage.

**HABITAT & RANGE**

Today the House Finch is found across all 48 contiguous United States, southern Canada, and Mexico. It thrives in urban and suburban environments, farmlands, forest edges, and desert scrub. Highly adaptable, it nests on building ledges, in ornamental conifers, hanging baskets, and even inside cacti in the Southwest. Unlike many finches, it does not undertake long migrations, remaining year-round across most of its range.

**DIET & FEEDING**

- Nyjer (thistle) seed — strongly preferred
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and hulled chips
- White millet scattered on platform feeders
- Wild berries: mulberry, pyracantha, crabapple
- Flower buds and plant shoots in spring
- Weed seeds from dandelion, chickweed, and thistle

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

House Finches are highly gregarious birds that gather in flocks of dozens or even hundreds outside the breeding season. They are cheerful, active, and vocal at feeders, often tolerating close human approach. Males sing a long, rambling warble year-round — one of the few North American songbirds that sings regularly through winter. Fascinatingly, the intensity of the male's red coloration is entirely diet-dependent: birds consuming more carotenoid-rich foods (berries, certain plants) develop brighter red plumage, while poorly-fed males may appear orange or yellow. Females actively choose the reddest males as mates, using color as a reliable indicator of foraging ability and health.

NESTING & BREEDING

House Finches are remarkably flexible nesters, using an extraordinary range of sites including tree cavities, cliff ledges, building eaves, hanging flower baskets, and old nests of other species. The female builds a compact cup of grasses, leaves, and fine plant fibers. Clutches of 2–6 pale blue eggs with dark speckles are incubated for 13–14 days by the female alone. The male feeds her during incubation. Nestlings fledge at 12–19 days. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per year, sometimes beginning a new nest before the previous brood has fully fledged.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The male House Finch produces one of the most melodious and sustained songs of any common feeder bird — a rich, cheerful warble lasting 3 seconds or more, delivered from a prominent perch. Song is heard year-round but peaks in spring. The call is a sharp "cheep" often given in flight. Flocks maintain contact with soft chirping notes while foraging together.

CONSERVATION STATUS

|                |               |                   |        |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|--------|
| IUCN Red List: | Least Concern | Population trend: | Stable |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|--------|

With an estimated population of over 267 million individuals, the House Finch is one of the most numerous birds in North America. However, populations in the eastern US suffered dramatic declines in the 1990s due to a contagious eye disease (Mycoplasmal conjunctivitis) that spread rapidly through feeder populations. Numbers have since partially recovered. If you see a finch with red, swollen, or crusty eyes at your feeder, clean feeders immediately with a 10% bleach solution.

FEEDER TIPS

- Tube feeders with small ports are ideal for finches
- Nyjer seed in a dedicated thistle sock attracts large flocks
- Clean feeders regularly — House Finches are susceptible to eye disease
- Platform feeders with millet attract ground-feeding individuals
- House Finches often feed in large, noisy groups — expect crowds

COLORING GUIDE

| ZONE                 | RECOMMENDED COLOR             |
|----------------------|-------------------------------|
| Head & breast (male) | Raspberry red to orange-red   |
| Back & wings         | Brown with dark streaking     |
| Belly                | White with brown streaks      |
| Rump (male)          | Reddish-pink                  |
| Female (entire)      | Plain brown, heavily streaked |
| Bill                 | Short, conical, gray-brown    |

# COLOR ME!

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